that participate in such military sales, specifically new F-16 fighters approved by the Trump administration.[43]

Other potential breakaway regions and disputed territories pose a similar danger, in Beijing's thinking. Despite promises in the 1984 Basic Framework agreed with Great Britain to respect Hong Kong's unique political status, China has steadily eroded Hong Kong's freedoms, particularly by meddling with the city's elected legislature and pressuring its courts. The Beijing-orchestrated kidnapping of a number of Hong Kong publishers (at least one of whom held a UK passport) in late 2015 further violated international law and underscored the city's vulnerability to the mainland. A proposed Hong Kong extradition law that would allow transfer to the mainland of those charged with crimes sparked massive demonstrations in the former British colony in July 2019, with up to two million protestors in the streets at times, and resulting in running battles between police and demonstrators that destroyed property and even led to the brief takeover of the Hong Kong Legislative Council building. Months of protests led Beijing to stage People's Armed Police units in Shenzhen, across from the island, and intimate that it would intervene if the Hong Kong government was not able to control protestors. This was a message not lost on Taiwanese, Tibetans, and others who saw in Hong Kong a proxy for many of their own problems with China.

China has put pressure on governments even away from areas it has traditionally claimed as its own. In the East China Sea, Beijing regularly uses private fishermen and maritime patrol vessels to challenge Japanese administrative control over the contested Senkaku/Diaoyu Islands, and it attempts to intimidate both Japan and Taiwan with naval flotillas, as well as by flying bombers near the airspace of both countries. Nor are its energies turned solely toward the oceans. Chinese forces have been in a face-off with Indian army troops high in the Himalayas over a disputed border with Bhutan.[44]

Perhaps most threateningly to the region, China has systematically moved to position itself as the dominant power in the South China Sea. For the past several years, Chinese naval vessels have attempted to